

vivid numbness of another life

*he sliced a
smile
into his face
like the joker*

is what soni told me
about the last he heard
of my friend M
and i imagine
those nerves
which felt,
severed.

i remember
us laughing
in fifth grade
about dwarf horses
i remember
playing airsoft and
the bulging welt
on his leg
once
when his mother
picked me up
and i piled
into a station wagon
with too many kids
for seat belts,
he asked
*why is your house bigger than ours
when our family has more people?*

the last time we hung out
was in middle school
before the drugs
before jail
before we stopped talking
just me, him, a park, a basketball.
arms now covered in tattoos,
he told me that
his (single) mother
had died from cancer
and
when i looked into his eyes,
there was no light—

blocked
by the demons
in his pupils.

it could have been me.

in elementary school,
M's spirit was full
of life, laughter, and feeling.
and now,
all i can think about
is soni's recitation,
and M's face

*so overly
unambiguous
that it becomes
ambiguous
again.*